



China's climate change measures

China unveils plans to start giant market to trade carbon credits for right to emit greenhouse gases. <http://digit.in/CCChinaMeasure>



Rare pig found

With the help of a hidden camera, scientists have filmed one of the world's rarest, and 'ugliest', pigs in a forest in Indonesia. <http://digit.in/RarePig>

Furry space pioneers

Prior to humans, it was animals who helped us shape up our journey to space

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efore Neil Armstrong walked on the surface of the moon, or Yuri Gagarin entered outer space,

Several animals had already visited the outer reaches of the atmosphere. Unfortunately, not all of them were a complete success. However, only because of these animals were we able to determine the exact conditions favourable for our survival in outer space. Based on these observa-

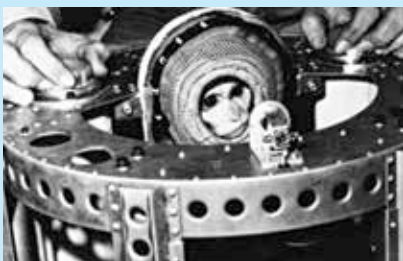
tions we built our spacecrafts that would allow humans to overcome the extreme conditions out there. The test subjects not only included dogs and chimps, but fruit flies, mice, cats and even rabbits were sent as explorers to outer space.

Right since the time we achieved flight using aircrafts and hot air balloons, animals were sent to high altitudes to test the conditions. The same tests were carried out when we built rockets and fruit flies were sent off to outer space on a V2 rocket on February 20, 1947. These fruit flies became the first living beings

in outer space and they landed back safely in parachutes after reaching a height of 108 kilometres. With the development of rocket engines, the space race officially kicked off and the world saw numerous experiments being conducted to one day send a man to space. Among those animals that were sent on these space missions, there were a few who broke and achieved new records. You must have definitely heard about Laika the dog, who was the first living being to orbit the Earth, and now, we'll be going through the other non-human pioneers of space travel.

Albert II

On June 14, 1949, Albert II was launched aboard a V2 rocket to a height 134 kilometres, becoming the first monkey in space. The previous candidate Albert was also launched on a similar rocket but the capsule only made it to a height of 63 kilometres and he probably died right after launch. Albert II was able to reach the final height alive, but a problem with the parachute led to his death due to the force of impact.



Credit: NASA

Laika

As the Soviet Union prepared for their second satellite launch with the Sputnik 2, the plans also included a living passenger on board. Dogs were the chosen candidates for the space mission. Stray dogs were the most favourable

since they were tough enough to survive the extreme outdoors, indicating that they could do the same for outer space. Among all the stray dogs, Laika was finally chosen to become the first dog and living being to orbit the Earth. Finally, on the evening of November 3, 1957, Sputnik 2 blasted off from Kazakhstan with her on board. Although the launch was a success, Laika couldn't survive the overwhelming stress and heat after several hours into flight and passed away.



Credit: Sputnik / Alamy